

Chapter 123-1

Liang Shi protected Xu Qingzhu very well, cushioning the back of her head with her hand, so that even when her back landed on the car seat, she didn't feel much impact.

It was just that the two of them were too close together.

The light inside the car was very dim, with only faint streetlight rays filtering in from outside, and Liang Shi was backlit.

Even though Xu Qingzhu had good eyesight, she still found it somewhat difficult to see clearly.

But she could see those pupils clearly.

In the dimness, the only thing reflected in those eyes was her own face.

She had clearly just said something threatening with an aggressive air, yet there wasn't a hint of threatening demeanor at all—instead, it made one find her amusing.

Those eyes held warmth, heat, and an intoxicating beauty.

The taste of alcohol seemed to still linger on Xu Qingzhu's lips and tongue. The drink was refreshing and sweet when it first entered the mouth, carrying a slight coolness, but as it flowed down the throat it became warm, burning the heart and lungs along with it.

One could tell without thinking that the aftertaste would be strong.

Xu Qingzhu had average alcohol tolerance and wasn't someone who drank much to begin with. She couldn't resist the alcohol's aftertaste at all, and her mind was now somewhat hazy.

She hadn't actually drunk much, but she had been made tipsy and slightly drunk by the alcoholic atmosphere in this cramped space.

"Then who should I like?" Xu Qingzhu's voice lilted upward at the end as she spoke, as if tinged with rich intoxication, her brows and eyes carrying smiles.

That face that seamlessly combined purity and allure was at this moment both innocent and enticing.

That cool, clear voice seemed coated with honey—sticky yet making one's heart tingle with a numb, itchy feeling.

Liang Shi paused, slightly dazed.

A few seconds later, Liang Shi leaned down and bit the side of her face, then bit the corner of her lips.

Purely, without a trace of amorous intent.

Xu Qingzhu's finger poked at her waist, then lightly pinched her.

Liang Shi said, "Anyway..."

She paused for a moment, "You can't like her."

Xu Qingzhu asked, "Why?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, her brows and eyes lowered, her long eyelashes fluttering a few times, casting shadows beneath her eyelids.

After a moment of silence in the cramped space, Liang Shi finally lifted her up and tightened the collar of her suit, the pads of her fingers still retaining the coolness from her skin.

Liang Shi's voice sounded, "I don't like Qi Jiao."

These words carried a hint of petulance, "So of course you can't like her either."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Liang Shi was drunk.

Her words were unclear.

Her head rested on Xu Qingzhu's shoulder, her voice murmuring, "You can like..."

Her voice trailed off here.

Xu Qingzhu looked down and found that she had closed her eyes and fallen asleep.

The most important part that followed was left unsaid.

The alcohol's aftertaste was strong enough to make one fall asleep quickly. It could also be that Liang Shi hadn't been resting well recently, had experienced many things during the day, was mentally exhausted by evening, and had relaxed after drinking a few glasses of wine, so she fell asleep very quickly.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu was only slightly tipsy.

She lowered her brows and eyes to look at Liang Shi, who had peacefully fallen asleep. Her slender, fair fingers landed on her jawline and gently traced along it.

Xu Qingzhu's voice was muffled, "What a dummy, jiejie~"¹

Footnotes:

¹ **Jiejie (姐姐):** Meaning "older sister" in Chinese. This is a significant term in this story, as it refers to the childhood bond between Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi when they were both kidnapped as children. Xu Qingzhu called young Liang Shi "jiejie" back then, and this term carries deep emotional weight representing their shared traumatic past and the protective role Liang Shi played.

Chapter 123-2

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When Liang Shi woke up the next day, there was no one home.

Xu Qingzhu had already gone to work.

It was probably her body's compensation mechanism at work—after those few glasses of wine last night, Liang Shi had slept soundly through the night.

She had directly made up for all the sleep she'd lost from staying up late and waking up early during her time with the film crew.

When she woke up, she was in the master bedroom, and she didn't feel too surprised, as if this was her room all along.

But as memories slowly came back together, she first thought of what happened at the bar last night—helplessly embarrassed, she ultimately felt it was too absurd.

Yet Xu Qingzhu had also indulged her in this absurdity.

Liang Shi picked up her phone to check messages. There was only one message sent by Chen Mian at three in the morning: 【I miss Qi Jiao.】

Just five short words, yet they made Liang Shi's mood this morning plummet like a roller coaster.

She replied: 【After this matter is over, let's go visit her grave.】

Qi Jiao's brief life was lived like a soulless shell—surely in death she couldn't still be just a nameless tombstone?

So they needed to help engrave Qi Jiao's own name on her tombstone.

Rather than letting her remain a wandering ghost even in death.¹

Liang Shi lay in bed for a while. When sunlight poured in through the gaps in the curtains, she raised her arm to block the sudden light.

She basked in the sun for a bit before getting up.

She had originally planned to get up and make some breakfast, but found that Xu Qingzhu had already placed the purchased breakfast on the dining table.

Liang Shi had just opened the packaging when the phone rang.

It was a call from the Municipal Public Security Bureau. Gu Xingyue's surgery had gone smoothly, and she had already woken up today.

At the same time, Gu Zhaoyuan had also rushed to the Municipal Public Security Bureau.

As the person who reported the case, Liang Shi needed to cooperate with the police investigation. Yesterday's statement was only a small part; because it involved a murder case from many years ago, Liang Shi still needed to come to the hospital.

This matter had attracted attention from higher-ups. For one, the person involved was considered a prominent entrepreneur in the city; for another, the nature of the case was egregious—it could no longer be classified as a simple family dispute.

The more than twenty stab wounds on Qi Xiangui's body alone were enough to make one's blood run cold.

Liang Shi hurriedly ate a few bites and drove to the hospital.

Chen Mian had probably drunk too much last night; she still hadn't woken up and hadn't replied to Liang Shi's message.

When Liang Shi arrived at the hospital, it happened to be Zhao Xuning's shift, and the two ran right into each other at the entrance.

The moment Zhao Xuning saw her, she adjusted her glasses and looked her up and down, her expression complicated.

Liang Shi immediately said, "I'm here to see someone."

Zhao Xuning made an "oh" sound, her voice as cool and detached as always, "I thought you were here to get an annual membership."

Liang Shi: "....."

Zhao Xuning was wearing a white shirt and black pants with a knee-length coat, her hair casually tied in a low ponytail—not much different from her usual attire.

The two walked side by side. Although Zhao Xuning was about the same height as Liang Shi, Zhao Xuning had developed an extremely fast walking pace from her usual work at the hospital. Liang Shi had to walk briskly to keep up with her rhythm.

The elevator wasn't too crowded at this hour. Liang Shi and Zhao Xuning entered and stood in a corner.

Remembering what happened that day at the film set, Liang Shi glanced sideways at Zhao Xuning again and again.

Zhao Xuning turned her face to look at her, "Something the matter?"

Liang Shi first shook her head, then Zhao Xuning asked, "Who are you here to see?"

"A friend." Liang Shi said, "It's not convenient for you to know."

Zhao Xuning paused for two seconds: "Gu Xingyue?"

Liang Shi: "....."

When she and Chen Mian came yesterday, they hadn't seen Zhao Xuning.

Yet she hadn't expected Zhao Xuning to guess it in one try.

"Her surgery was performed by our department head." Zhao Xuning said, "I assisted."

Even as doctors, they didn't often encounter this type of patient in their daily work—eight wounds on her body in total, each one avoiding vital points, yet each one was a major bleeding site. The slightest carelessness would have meant she couldn't be saved.

At the time, their department head had even guessed while performing the surgery whether this person was a medical student.

Though that was just a joke.

Moreover, Gu Xingyue had one wound on her body that was a fatal injury—that cut landed on her waist, twenty centimeters long, and suturing alone took over three hours.

Because she was designated as a key protected individual by the Municipal Public Security Bureau, they had used the hospital's most prestigious doctors. They hadn't dared to use interns as assistants—the physicians had directly stepped in themselves.

After that surgery was completed, their elderly department head had gone to get a glucose drip.

When Zhao Xuning saw that face, she knew it was Qi Jiao. But unexpectedly, when recording the patient information after the surgery, the name recorded was actually Gu Xingyue.

She wanted to investigate, so she used some connections and asked a relative who worked at the Municipal Bureau. Naturally, she learned some inside information.

At the same time, the Municipal Public Security Bureau had also sent over samples for DNA testing.

Given that Zhao Xuning already knew something about this matter, with all this additional information, what couldn't she deduce?

There were too many people in the elevator, so it wasn't convenient to discuss these things. When getting off the elevator, Zhao Xuning's footsteps paused slightly, and she finally called to Liang Shi: "Come with me."

Footnotes:

¹ **Wandering ghost (孤魂野鬼):** In Chinese folk beliefs, spirits of the dead who have no one to make offerings to them or who are not properly buried become "lonely souls and wild ghosts" (孤魂野鬼), doomed to wander without rest. Having one's name on a tombstone and receiving proper ancestral rites is considered essential for the deceased's peace in the afterlife.

Chapter 123-3

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Liang Shi still didn't know that Zhao Xuning already knew everything. After arriving at her office, she grabbed a chair and sat down, while Zhao Xuning removed her glasses and placed them on the desk, then took out a white coat from the cabinet.

Liang Shi asked, "Why did you ask me to come here?"

Zhao Xuning first frowned as she disinfected the white coat. The office was soon filled with the pungent smell of disinfectant, and Liang Shi covered her nose with her hand.

After the disinfection was complete, Zhao Xuning hung the white coat on the coat rack, then crossed her arms and looked at Liang Shi: "There's an eighty percent chance that the wounds on Gu Xingyue's body were self-inflicted. The placement and depth of the cuts are very similar."

"...So they weren't inflicted by someone else?" Liang Shi was surprised.

Zhao Xuning said, "There were also wounds inflicted by others, and those wounds are quite serious."

"Did you report this situation?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Of course, but all her wounds look like they were inflicted by others, so they were all reported as such."

Liang Shi: "....."

"After Qi Jiao passed away, Mrs. Qi found Gu Xingyue to act as Qi Jiao's stand-in, right?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi hesitated for a moment, then asked uncertainly, "Why are you asking about this?"

Zhao Xuning fell silent.

"There's something I have here, and I'm not sure whether I should tell you." Zhao Xuning said, "I'm still thinking about it."

Liang Shi: "?"

"What is Gu Xingyue's true identity?" Zhao Xuning asked, "Can her biological parents be found?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "She was a child adopted by the director of the former Angel Orphanage. She was abandoned at the orphanage's doorstep right after she was born."

Zhao Xuning frowned in thought, returned to her desk and pulled open a drawer, finding a document pressed at the very bottom.

It was in a dark-colored folder, appearing very solemn.

Liang Shi was puzzled: "What do you want to tell me?"

"You'll know once you look at it." Zhao Xuning pushed the folder over.

Liang Shi glanced at her suspiciously, not knowing what she was up to.¹

At first, she was calm and composed when opening the folder, but a few minutes later she was holding her breath in concentration, until she finished reading the very last word.

"This..." Liang Shi was so surprised she couldn't speak.

"As you can see." Zhao Xuning's arms rested on the wooden desk, her brows furrowed, "So, are you close with her?"

"Are you close with this person?" Liang Shi asked her in return.

A moment later, the two answered each other simultaneously, speaking in unison: "Sort of."

Nothing else needed to be said.

This document was a DNA test report. Zhao Xuning had taken Gu Xingyue's hair and compared it with a person named Feng Xian, and the results showed that the two were mother and daughter.

Liang Shi's heart was already in turmoil. After the initial shock passed, Liang Shi was finally able to calmly ask Zhao Xuning: "Why do you have this?"

"Feng Xian is my patient." Zhao Xuning said, "When I first came to this hospital, it was her first hospitalization. But her blood type is special—it's a relatively rare type among Omega blood types. At that time, she was hospitalized for anemia, but the hospital blood bank had no blood type compatible with hers, so they gave her Type O-AB blood."

Liang Shi didn't really understand this world's blood type rules either, so she could only quietly listen to Zhao Xuning explain.

Actually, the reason was simple: Feng Xian's blood type was so special that very few people could be compatible with her. There were only about a hundred or so people in the entire world with this blood type, and people with this blood type were more prone to developing anemia and other diseases during middle and old age, requiring extra care in daily life.

Yesterday, after Gu Xingyue was sent to the hospital, she needed a large blood transfusion due to excessive blood loss.

But unexpectedly, her blood type was also Type O-S, the same blood type as Feng Xian.

Zhao Xuning hadn't been practicing at the hospital for long, but she had asked their department head whether they had ever encountered a patient with Type O-S blood in their previous career. The head had also shaken her head, saying the last time she encountered one was when doing research abroad.

The blood bank only had a small amount of Type O-S blood, all of which had been donated in small quantities by Feng Xian after she recovered from her illness.

After Gu Xingyue received the same blood type, she initially absorbed it well, but unexpectedly, a rejection reaction occurred half an hour later. With no other choice, they could only give her Type O-AB blood instead.

Rejection reactions during blood transfusions vary depending on individual constitution. Omegas often experience this situation due to their special body structure.

So no one else thought anything of it.

But Zhao Xuning had met Feng Xian before, and Feng Xian had mentioned during her hospitalization that she once had a daughter, but her daughter was lost.

Gu Xingyue's face bore about forty percent resemblance to Feng Xian.

Footnotes:

¹ **Not knowing what she was up to (不知她葫蘆裏賣得什麼藥):** This is a Chinese idiom that literally translates to "not knowing what medicine is being sold in her gourd." In ancient China, traveling doctors would carry medicine in gourds, and this phrase came to mean not knowing someone's true intentions or what they're planning.

Chapter 123-4

After Gu Xingyue's surgery was completed, the Municipal Public Security Bureau had asked them to take Gu Xingyue's hair sample and compare it with the sample sent over for DNA testing. Zhao Xuning had done this as well while she was at it.

The result...

Was also something she hadn't anticipated.

Because of this matter, Zhao Xuning had even gone to Feng Xian's home last night.

Feng Xian was not only her first patient, but also a professor at Qingyi University's School of Literature.

She had tutored Zhao Xuning during middle school, so she could be considered half a teacher.

When she arrived, Feng Xian was watching television. The TV was playing a lively scene of families reuniting under countless lights. She was wearing casual home pajamas and opened the door for her with sleepy eyes.

She even warmly invited her to stay for a meal.

It was also Zhao Xuning's first time visiting, but after seeing her state, she didn't know what to say.

Gu Xingyue was still in the hospital, and she didn't know what her attitude would be.

So she didn't dare act rashly.

She could only simply have a meal and then leave Feng Xian's home.

After Liang Shi heard all these twists and turns, she was silent for a long time.

"What about Feng Xian's husband?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning said, "Dead. And he died after they divorced."

Liang Shi: "....."

As Zhao Xuning spoke, she took out her phone, typed a line in the browser to search, and handed over the relevant news she found.

"This matter caused quite a stir back then." Zhao Xuning said, "Feng Xian's husband's surname was Gao. He originally ran a fairly successful company, but during a gathering, their newborn daughter went missing. The couple searched for a long time without success, arguing every day. To find their daughter, the two spent nearly ten million yuan."

The result was, of course, obvious. Their daughter wasn't found, the company went from bad to worse, and ultimately, the couple who once had a great relationship wore away all their affection through mutual blame after losing their daughter.

It could only end in the bleak outcome of divorce.

After the divorce, the company went into bankruptcy liquidation. Mr. Gao, who had essentially lost both his family and his fortune, jumped from the company rooftop, choosing to end his life this way.

At the time, it was mainly because of the company's poor business situation. It had been an emerging and popular company with bright development prospects, but no one expected it to end so tragically.

It made many people sigh with regret.

Multiple media outlets rushed to report on this company's affairs, and the trigger that led to the company's bankruptcy was naturally dug up by the media, causing a sensation at the time.

After Liang Shi finished reading, her heart was full of sighs.

"Has Feng Xian never remarried since then?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "Probably not, though I'm not too sure. When I went last night, she was living alone."

Liang Shi closed the folder properly and pushed it back to Zhao Xuning, "This matter... let's wait until Gu Xingyue has dealt with things here before bringing it up. Her current physical and mental state probably can't handle thinking about two things at once."

Though fortunately, she still had family.

Zhao Xuning pressed that document back to the very bottom again, then said with a sudden change to a cold demeanor: "Alright, you can leave now."

Liang Shi: "?"

Although she already knew this was just how Zhao Xuning was, Liang Shi couldn't help but say: "You won't even pour me a glass of water?"

Zhao Xuning: "...You didn't even talk that much."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Liang Shi smiled: "Isn't this basic human courtesy?"

Zhao Xuning frowned and answered seriously: "My office only has yesterday's water."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi had lost this one.

However...

Liang Shi suddenly asked: "Why did you tell me about Gu Xingyue's situation?"

A flash of confusion passed through Zhao Xuning's eyes, but she said: "Who else should I tell? Besides, you're the person who can stand in Gu Xingyue's position and make the best choice for her."

Liang Shi: "....."

She had to admit, this trust from Zhao Xuning made Liang Shi feel quite pleased.

So before leaving her office, Liang Shi couldn't help but say: "Oh right, Dr. Zhao, do you know someone named Yan Lin?"

Zhao Xuning paused for a moment, "Sounds somewhat familiar."

Liang Shi said in a roundabout way: "This person seems quite nice~ Standing next to Dr. Shen, they look very well-matched too."

She deliberately said this last part in a teasing tone, and after saying it, even she felt her tone was too impudent.

So before Zhao Xuning could react, she immediately fled from her office.

Zhao Xuning stood there dazed for two seconds, then flipped through her phone.

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Yan Lin, huh.

If she recalled correctly, she and Shen Hui had gotten into a fight once because of Yan Lin.

Chapter 123-5

It was winter in Haizhou City. The weather was gloomy, with snow about to fall but not quite falling yet.

Zhao Xuning had classes in the evening that lasted until nine o'clock. That night, because of a group project, she couldn't accompany Shen Hui for dinner. She had been hungry the whole time herself, and as class was about to end, she asked Shen Hui if she wanted to go get a late-night snack.

But Shen Hui didn't reply to her message.

Zhao Xuning assumed she was busy and put her phone back in her pocket. But a few minutes later, she couldn't control her hands anymore. The moment the teacher dismissed class, she sent messages to Shen Hui.

【Baby, I want to eat a late-night snack.】

【Wifey, what are you doing?】

【Baby wifey... pay attention to me, I'm going to starve to death.】

She sent seven or eight messages in a row, but Shen Hui only replied with one voice message: "Ah... baby wifey, I already ate dinner outside with a friend and haven't gone home yet. How about I order delivery for you?"

Zhao Xuning's heart instantly sank to the bottom. She replied sulkily: 【Forget it, I won't eat anymore.】

She had thought Shen Hui would coax her like before, but there was no follow-up.

After class, her classmates did invite her to get a late-night snack, but she refused with a cold face.

She walked alone toward their place. On the way back, it started to snow—winter in Haizhou City had quietly arrived.

Zhao Xuning took out her phone again and again to check for messages, thinking she might have put it on silent and that's why she didn't receive Shen Hui's messages. But the truth was that Shen Hui really hadn't replied to her.

This was something that rarely happened after they started dating.

Speaking of her and Shen Hui, it was somewhat like love at first sight, yet after mutual testing, they got together like thunder striking fire.¹

Their relationship progressed quickly, and they moved in together just as fast.

After they started dating came the honeymoon phase, and they rarely argued.

Because Zhao Xuning spoke little and was younger, Shen Hui would always yield to her somewhat.

At first, Zhao Xuning thought it was because Shen Hui had grown up in a difficult environment and was therefore used to yielding to others. Only later did she learn that Shen Hui was the dignified Second Miss of the Shen family—from childhood to adulthood, it was always others who yielded to her.

Shen Hui yielded to her simply because of love.

It was also then, when Zhao Xuning recalled all the little moments between them, that she suddenly realized their love was truly pure.

She had also learned to bow her head for Shen Hui, and Shen Hui had also lowered herself for her.

In that relationship, Zhao Xuning wasn't that cold and pampered genius, an untouchable flower on a high peak,² and Shen Hui wasn't the proud and domineering Second Miss of the Shen family. They simply existed as each other's girlfriends, nothing more.

But that day, Zhao Xuning had only eaten one meal, and even that was very little. It was already a busy time at school with heavy coursework. Since Zhao Xuning couldn't eat with Shen Hui, she felt unmotivated to do anything.

While she was still feeling gloomy about not receiving any messages from Shen Hui, at the entrance of their residential complex, Zhao Xuning saw a scene of a tall girl standing with Shen Hui.

Snow was falling in flurries, shrouding the world in a layer of haze. The snowflakes under the dim yellow streetlights looked especially beautiful.

It should have been a scene as beautiful as something from a movie, but to Zhao Xuning, it was an eyesore.

Shen Hui was laughing and chatting, playfully throwing a punch at the other person as if in mock reproach. The two of them looked very familiar with each other.

And the other person extended a long arm to put a hat on Shen Hui.

Zhao Xuning stood there, her mind going blank, even her breathing stopping for a few seconds.

Her complexion was terrible.

In that instant, she thought of so many things—all about how to punish Shen Hui.

Yet she never thought about breaking up.

She even thought: as long as Shen Hui didn't bring it up, could she just pretend not to know?

Zhao Xuning was startled by herself when this thought emerged. She lowered her brows and eyes, turned her face away and didn't look anymore, planning to turn around and go back to school.

It was Shen Hui who called out to her, "Ningning!"

With a hint of excitement and joy, Zhao Xuning turned around, only to see Shen Hui jogging toward her through the falling snow.

Zhao Xuning didn't even have time to react; she could only reach out and embrace her.

Shen Hui nestled in her arms, reaching out to touch her eyelashes, and immediately began to coax her gently: "Baby wifey, have you eaten?"

Her heart, which had been retreating, suddenly moved forward in that instant, because Shen Hui came to coax her.

Zhao Xuning coldly watched the girl who had already left; she could only vaguely see the shadow of her car.

That silver BMW sped away through the snow.

"You still care about me?" Zhao Xuning let go of her and said coldly, "I thought you only remembered other people now."

"There's no one else." Shen Hui went to hold her hand, but Zhao Xuning shoved her hands in her pockets and moved far away from her, "Who was that person just now?"

Emboldened by Shen Hui's gentle coaxing, Zhao Xuning became aggressive.

In Shen Hui's eyes, her jealous appearance was also adorable.

Shen Hui was willing to explain to her patiently, saying that was her high school classmate Yan Lin, who was the top student in their class and was liked by many people. The two of them had a good relationship, but they didn't keep in touch often now.

Shen Hui said it was impossible for her and Yan Lin to become lovers, because...

"I already have you, baby wifey." Shen Hui threw herself directly into her arms, hugging her tightly, "Don't even think about getting rid of me."

Zhao Xuning was coaxed until her head was spinning, but when they went home that night, she was still pretending to be angry.

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Their argument only lasted for a brief two minutes.

Because even after Shen Hui explained many times, Zhao Xuning was still angry. So Shen Hui got angry, struggled out of her arms, grabbed a pillow, and was going to sleep in the guest room.

But the moment she reached the guest room door, Zhao Xuning ran over and scooped her up in a princess carry, carrying her back to the master bedroom.

That sexually indifferent face had no expression, but as she pressed Shen Hui down on the bed, she said in a muffled voice: "Wifey, don't get too close to them. I'm not happy about it."

Footnotes:

¹ **Thunder striking fire (天雷勾地火):** A Chinese idiom describing an instant, explosive attraction between two people, like lightning striking and causing a fire—an irresistible, passionate connection.

² **Untouchable flower on a high peak (高嶺之花):** A phrase describing someone who appears cold, aloof, and difficult to approach, like a beautiful flower growing on a high mountain ridge that ordinary people cannot reach.

Chapter 123-6

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Zhao Xuning used to always be like this.

When Shen Hui was coaxing her, she would push her luck.

But whenever Shen Hui got angry, she would be the one to coax her.

Between them, with this give and take, they could always find the most comfortable balance.

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The past was once again stirred up by that name from Liang Shi's mouth. Zhao Xuning sat wearily in her chair, the chair turned away from the desk, and she raised her arm to cover her eyes.

In the end, did she still have to move forward?

Zhao Xuning let out a soft breath, her heart aching with a twisting pain.

She thought: then she would wish Shen Hui happiness in a world without her.

Having left this jerk behind, Shen Hui would be better off, right?

She would eat properly now, right?

She wouldn't keep getting thinner anymore.

Shen Hui deserved better.

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Liang Shi originally didn't want to interfere in the matters between Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui, but Zhao Xuning had given her too much.

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After leaving Zhao Xuning's office, Liang Shi came to the place the Municipal Public Security Bureau had notified her about.

Gu Xingyue had just woken up, so naturally she couldn't undergo a long interview.

Before Liang Shi arrived, Gu Xingyue had already been interviewed once. She spoke weakly, but her logic was clear as she recounted everything.

Including how Qi Xiangui was killed by Yang Jiani.

That day, Qi Xiangui had a social engagement and came home very late, yet he demanded that Gu Xingyue play the piano for him. Gu Xingyue made an excuse saying she wasn't feeling well—she actually had a slight fever—so she tried to refuse.

Unexpectedly, Qi Xiangui casually grabbed a vase and hurled it at her, "You useless thing, go play for me!"

Gu Xingyue didn't want to, but as a result, Qi Xiangui grabbed her by the back of her neck and dragged her to the piano. Her head even slammed hard against the piano. Seeing this, Yang Jiani stepped forward to intervene.

The drunk Qi Xiangui directly slapped Yang Jiani across the face. Because of the excessive force, Yang Jiani was thrown to the ground entirely. Gu Xingyue went to help her up, while Qi Xiangui cursed: "You damn woman, I feed you well and give you a good life so you can take care of our daughter at home properly. Look at this thing you've raised!"

To Qi Xiangui, she was just a tool for showing off.

Not his daughter, not even a person.

Hearing this, Gu Xingyue glared at him furiously. Her gaze irritated Qi Xiangui, and he swung another slap at her.

Her face immediately turned red, with obvious finger marks on the right side.

Yang Jiani went to protect her. This action infuriated Qi Xiangui even more, so he began punching and kicking both of them.

The strength of an adult male Alpha was something two Omega women couldn't withstand. Especially since Qi Xiangui had been drinking—his fists landing on them felt like huge rocks smashing down, causing dense, throbbing pain everywhere.

And when he kicked, it was with enough force to nearly break Gu Xingyue's ribs.

Unable to bear the pain any longer, Gu Xingyue said: "I'll go play."

With disheveled hair, she sat before the piano, her fingers trembling as they landed on the keys. But she couldn't even play a complete piece.

Qi Xiangui kicked her in the back.

Gu Xingyue snapped, yelling: "To you, playing the piano is no different from fluffing cotton anyway!¹ You can't tell the difference at all!"

There was still blood on her face, making her look fierce.

These words directly enraged Qi Xiangui, as if she had stepped on his tail. He kicked her once more.

Gu Xingyue cried and yelled at the same time: "I just can't play! You don't need to hit Mom anymore—just kill me instead!"

Qi Xiangui's absolute position as head of the household was being challenged. Facing Gu Xingyue's defiant gaze, Qi Xiangui first pinned her to the ground and beat her. But Yang Jiani, fearing she would be beaten to death, immediately rushed over to shield her.

And Gu Xingyue kept howling: "Mom, don't interfere! Just let him kill me! Let me die! He can go to prison! That way you won't have to suffer for the rest of your life!"

Hearing this, Qi Xiangui suddenly said coldly: "Did Yang Jiani fucking teach you this? Fine, so you want to kill us all off and then continue being your Yang family's eldest miss by yourself, is that it?! Dream on!"

Qi Xiangui then viciously beat Yang Jiani.

Gu Xingyue went to protect Yang Jiani again, continuously provoking Qi Xiangui: "If you have the guts, then kill me! I'm not even a person to you anyway! I'm just a tool you use to show off! Kill me then!"

She looked as if she had gone mad, afraid of neither pain nor death—completely different from her usual delicate and weak appearance.

Footnotes:

¹ **Fluffing cotton (彈棉花):** This is a traditional Chinese craft where cotton is beaten/fluffed with a special bow-like tool to make it soft for quilts and bedding. The Chinese word for playing an instrument (彈) is the same as the word for fluffing/beating cotton, so Gu Xingyue is making a bitter joke that to someone as uncultured as Qi Xiangui, the refined art of piano playing might as well be the crude labor of fluffing cotton—he can't appreciate the difference anyway.

Chapter 123-7

The drunk Qi Xiangui was stunned for a few seconds, then in his rage began searching everywhere for a weapon. He threw two or three vases at Gu Xingyue, but she wasn't injured.

He kept searching everywhere for tools, and somehow produced a knife from somewhere. "Come, let's try this."

"You little wench, daring to provoke me." Qi Xiangui spoke in a thuggish manner, "When I was playing with knives, you didn't even know where you were yet. I give you food and drink, and asking you to play a little piano is too much? You even want to threaten me with death? After you're dead, I'll just have another one—more obedient than you, better behaved than you, and smarter than you too. You've been sickly and stupid since you were little, nothing like my daughter! Who knows where your slutty mother got herself knocked up!"

These words made Yang Jiani roar in fury, but unexpectedly Qi Xiangui kicked her away and pointed the knife directly at Gu Xingyue's face.

Just as the knife was about to land on Gu Xingyue's face, Yang Jiani found a wrench from somewhere and smashed it directly onto his head. Qi Xiangui died on the spot.

After he died, Yang Jiani stabbed him again and again right in front of Gu Xingyue.

According to Gu Xingyue, Qi Xiangui's eyes hadn't closed yet at that time—he was in a state of "dying with eyes open."¹

Having suffered this fright, Gu Xingyue developed a fever that very night. She didn't know how Yang Jiani subsequently disposed of the body. It was only the next evening that the two had a minor argument.

Yang Jiani then threatened to kill her just like that day. Gu Xingyue was stabbed several times, and in the emergency, she dialed "1"—her friend Liang Shi's speed dial number—to have her call the police, while she herself stalled Yang Jiani.

Fortunately, she was saved because of this.

After giving this testimony, Gu Xingyue's face was as pale as paper, as if she could faint at any moment.

The police collected all this testimony and then asked Liang Shi whether she knew about the relationships within their family.

Liang Shi shook her head.

The police also learned from Gu Xingyue's testimony that Yang Jiani had shown abusive tendencies long ago, and that her biological daughter Qi Jiao had been abused to death in the same manner.

And Liang Shi was also among those who had suffered such harm, so the police asked Liang Shi about her childhood experiences.

Liang Shi answered each question.

Although the statute of limitations for these matters had already passed, and there was no direct evidence to prove Yang Jiani had done these things.

But submitting these as corroborating evidence would increase the severity of Yang Jiani's sentence.

After finishing her account, Liang Shi asked somewhat hesitantly: "Officer, if it's discovered that Yang Jiani has a mental illness, will she receive a lighter punishment?"

The police officer taking the statement was momentarily stunned, then said: "Normally speaking, that would be the case, but her situation is too special. Right now, our country places particular emphasis on domestic violence cases—it's a hot-button issue. Her sentencing should be quite severe."

After hearing this, Liang Shi let out a slight breath of relief, "That's good then."

After giving her statement, Liang Shi wanted to go into the hospital room to see Gu Xingyue, but she was resting, so Liang Shi could only wait.

When she went home that evening, Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu everything that had happened during the day. Xu Qingzhu said: "Gu Xingyue probably doesn't want to see you recently."

"Why?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu was flipping through a novel with a blue cover, one about war. She read while speaking: "To be precise, she won't want to see anyone. She arranged this plan flawlessly, using her own life as the price to obtain this chance to have Yang Jiani sentenced. She won't want any secrets to be leaked through conversations with you."

"If I were Gu Xingyue, I would do the same." Xu Qingzhu said, "Once I meet with you, no matter what state I'm in when I see you, it would arouse suspicion."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi held the opposite view, thinking that Gu Xingyue should be willing to see her.

At the very least, she would chat with her about her state of mind.

But over the following days when she went to the hospital several more times, the response she got was always that the patient was currently weak and it wasn't convenient to receive visitors.

Liang Shi, standing in the hospital corridor: "....."

In matters like this, Xu Qingzhu was always more accurate in her predictions than she was.

Meanwhile, Yang Jiani, who had been arrested and taken to the police station, did not honestly confess her crimes. She wouldn't eat or drink, and didn't say a single word.

She completely refused to cooperate with the police investigation.

It wasn't until the third day that Yang Jiani finally said to the police: "I want to see my Jiaojiao."

The police said coldly: "Qi Jiao was killed by you thirteen years ago. Where are you going to see her?"

The cold room fell into dead silence. After a moment, Yang Jiani said: "Then I want to see Gu Xingyue. Otherwise, I won't confess."

The police: "....."

By this time, Gu Xingyue's body had recovered somewhat. The police specially sent a car to bring Gu Xingyue over, and the two met through a transparent window.

Yang Jiani looked at her with a cold smile, "I really didn't expect that I had raised a tiger that would bring me disaster."²

Gu Xingyue's expression was indifferent, her face pale as paper without a trace of color. She only said coldly: "From the moment you treated Qi Jiao as your possession, you were wrong."

Hearing this, Yang Jiani suddenly roared in fury: "What did I do wrong?! She's my daughter! She belongs to me!"

Gu Xingyue: "....."

"Qi Jiao was truly pitiful." Gu Xingyue said, "She never had a life of her own."

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It was also on this day that Liang Shi felt somewhat unwell. It was probably because of the recent drop in temperature—the window hadn't been closed tightly at night, and she had been exposed to cold wind all night, leaving her dizzy and muddled.

She slept through the entire afternoon. At dusk, when red clouds filled the sky, Liang Shi poured herself a cup of warm water. Even after drinking it all in one gulp, she still felt thirsty. She raised her hand to touch her forehead but couldn't tell whether she had a fever or not.

Liang Shi gulped down a few more mouthfuls of water. She was just about to pick up her phone to ask Xu Qingzhu when she would be back, but the moment she unlocked it, a notification popped up at the top of the screen.

It was a picture sent by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi smiled, thinking to herself that this was probably the legendary telepathy between hearts?

Following that thought, she also remembered that tomorrow would be her one hundredth day in this world. From late summer to early winter, and she still hadn't completed the mission.

Perhaps... this mission couldn't be completed after all.

But it didn't matter anyway.

As Liang Shi was thinking this, she tapped open the chat window, and the picture appeared on the screen.

In that instant, the smile froze on Liang Shi's face, and her blood ran cold.

The water cup in her other hand dropped to the ground, shattering with a crash.

She enlarged the photo—it was shockingly Xu Qingzhu, bound in a dark corner!

Footnotes:

¹ **Dying with eyes open (死不瞑目):** A Chinese expression meaning to die with unresolved grievances or unfulfilled wishes, unable to close one's eyes in peace. It describes someone who dies in a state of shock, anger, or with deep regrets.

² **Raised a tiger that would bring disaster (養虎為患):** A Chinese idiom meaning to nurture a potential threat that eventually turns against you—like raising a tiger cub that grows up to attack its owner. Yang Jiani is saying she didn't expect the person she raised (Gu Xingyue) would become someone who would bring about her downfall.